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SFB 1718 Common Ground

Modeling Common Ground Across Divides:
Interdisciplinary Approaches to
Polarized Political Discourse

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Reportative parentheticals and Common Ground

Plausible deniability and discourse commitments

1 Goals & research questions

- Reportatives attribute a proposition to a non-speaker source, as a type of evidential (Aikhenvald 2018).

(1) John said that it will rain tomorrow.

- Reportative parentheticals (a.k.a. *slifting parentheticals* Ross 1973; Koev 2021, 2022) are set off prosodically from the proposition and are not syntactically embedding.

(2) It will rain tomorrow, John said.

- The speaker avoids comitting to the proposition and merely entertains it (Jackendoff 2025).
- Depending on the source, reportatives are used as *figleaves* (Saul 2024) to cover up controversial claims (*everyone knows, experts say*).

Research questions:

- Do reportatives decrease the speaker's trustworthiness?
- Does the position of a reportative (embedding vs. parenthetical) have an effect on the degree of speaker trustworthiness?
- What are the requirements on a plausible model of Common Ground?

2 Theoretical background

- Assumption: in assertions, the speaker is committed to the truth of the proposition and is socially responsible for it (Searle 1969; Krifka 2021, 2023).
- Linguistic perspective: embedding vs. parenthetical reportatives differ syntactically (embedding/parenthetical) → different effects?
  - Embedding reportative makes external source clear from the start (Urmson 1952) → early indication of speaker intention.
  - Parenthetical reportative in final position revises default speaker commmitment → recency effects.
- Parentheticals split the sentence into two parts, the at-issue proposition and the secondary information that does not address the QUD (Koev 2022) → *double assertion*.
- Syntactic perspective: is there a derivational relation between the two positions (Ross 1973) or is the parenthetical version not syntactically connected to the host Jackendoff 2025?

3 More complex cases

(3) You know, America is blessed with elections. All over the world they talk about our elections. You know what the world says about us now? They said, we don't have free and fair elections. **And you know what else [. . .]? We don't have a free and fair press.**
(Donald Trump, 6 January 2021)

→ Ellipsis ambiguates who is committed to the proposition.

(4) a. Q: And you know what else [~~the world says about us now~~]?
b. Q: And you know what else [~~we don't have~~]?

(5) a. Q(4a) → [~~They say~~] We don't have a free and fair press.
b. Q(4b) → We don't have a free and fair press.

- Depending on the interpretation of the ellided content. . .
  - it is not clear whether Trump expresses his commitment to the proposition
  - or whether it is still under the scope of the reportative
- Ambiguous QUD leads to potentially different CG updates → defectiveness and multiple CGs (Peet 2021)?
- How problematic is this potential defectiveness for future communication?

4 Experimental design (work in progress)

- 1×3 design: no reportative vs. embedding reportative vs. parenthetical reportative.
- Embedded in a discourse context that introduces a speaker *Mary*, who talks about mutual friends.
- Question: how trustworthy is Mary as a speaker?
- Participants rate Mary's trustworthiness on a 7-point Likert scale.

(6) a. Peter bought a new sports car last week. [no reportative]
b. John said Peter bought a new sports car last week. [embedding reportative]
c. Peter bought a new sports car last week, John said. [parenthetical reportative]

Hypotheses:

- The presence of a reportative decreases speaker trustworthiness.
- The position of a reportative (embedding vs. parenthetical) has an effect on the degree of speaker trustworthiness.

- Is there a difference in speaker trustwortiness between the embedding and parenthetical reportative?
- Do participants even pick up on the presence of a reportative?
- Is there evidence for a syntactic relation between the two positions?

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